~~수고하세요, 팀장님!~~

The AI Korean Trap Checklist

20 phrases AI translators get wrong, what Koreans say instead, and a 7-point check to run before you hit send.

Before you send anything AI wrote

Run down this list. If you tick a box, look up the fix on the next pages.

- [ ] **Who will read this?**
  Older, more senior, or a stranger? Then every sentence needs **요** or **-습니다**. Plain endings are for close friends and juniors.
- [ ] **Delete every 당신.**
  Korean drops “you” or uses a name and title instead. 당신 to a coworker can sound like the start of an argument.
- [ ] **No 씨 for anyone above you.**
  Use the job title with 님: 팀장님, 교수님, 부장님. 씨 is only for peers and juniors.
- [ ] **Saying sorry or “got it” upward?**
  Use **죄송합니다** and **알겠습니다**, not 미안해요 or 알았어요.
- [ ] **Is an elder eating, sleeping or “being” somewhere?**
  Swap the verb itself: 드시다, 주무시다, 계시다.
- [ ] **Did AI translate an English idiom word for word?**
  “I hope this email finds you well”, “Bless you”, “Thank you for the meal”. Korean has its own fixed phrase, or says nothing.
- [ ] **Replying “네.” in a chat?**
  A bare 네 with a period reads cold. Soften it: **넵!** or **네~**

Talking to someone above you

Bosses, professors, clients, elders. This is where AI does the most damage.

What AI gives you	What Koreans say
Leaving work before your boss ~~수고하세요~~	**먼저 들어가 보겠습니다.** meon-jeo deu-reo-ga bo-get-seum-ni-da "Keep working hard" directs someone's labor. Said upward, it sounds condescending.
Your manager gives you a task ~~알았어요~~	**네, 알겠습니다.** ne, al-get-seum-ni-da 알았어요 sounds like a reluctant "Fine, I heard you."
Emailing your team leader, Kim ~~김 씨~~	**김 팀장님** gim tim-jang-nim Surname + 씨 can sound like you're talking down to them. Superiors get a title.
Handing in late work to a professor ~~미안해요~~	**늦게 제출해서 정말 죄송합니다.** neut-ge je-chul-hae-seo jeong-mal joe-song-ham-ni-da 미안하다 is for equals. Upward, it sounds like you aren't taking it seriously.
Inviting your grandmother to eat ~~먹으세요~~	**맛있게 드세요.** ma-sit-ge deu-se-yo A few verbs change completely for elders. 먹다 becomes 드시다.
Asking an older neighbor's age ~~몇 살이에요?~~	**연세가 어떻게 되세요?** yeon-se-ga eo-tteo-ke doe-se-yo 몇 살 is how you ask a child. Elders get 연세, adults get 나이.
Asking a coworker if they ate ~~당신은 점심 먹었어요?~~	**점심 드셨어요?** jeom-sim deu-syeo-sseo-yo Just drop "you". Context does the work.

Work chats and emails

What AI gives you	What Koreans say
Your team leader messages you on KakaoTalk ~~네.~~	**넵!** nep In chat, a bare 네 with a period can read as flat or annoyed.
Opening a first email to a professor ~~이 이메일이 잘 도착하길 바랍니다~~	**안녕하세요, ○○대학교 김소피입니다.** an-nyeong-ha-se-yo, ○○ dae-hak-gyo gim-so-pi-im-ni-da There's no Korean version of the English idiom. Greet, then say who you are.
Introducing yourself on day one ~~만나서 반갑고 함께 일하기를 기대합니다~~	**앞으로 잘 부탁드립니다.** ap-eu-ro jal bu-tak-deu-rim-ni-da The literal sentence sounds like a speech. Leaving out 잘 부탁드립니다 feels like something is missing.

Phrases that don't mean what AI says

What AI gives you	What Koreans say
A clerk offers a bag and you want one ~~괜찮아요~~	**네, 주세요.** ne, ju-se-yo After an offer, 괜찮아요 means "No thanks." Learners refuse things by accident.
A coworker asks 밥 먹었어요? *(explaining your lunch)*	**네, 먹었어요. 식사하셨어요?** ne, meo-geo-sseo-yo. sik-sa-ha-syeo-sseo-yo It's a greeting, closer to "How's it going?" Answer briefly and ask back.
Someone says 언제 밥 한번 먹어요! *(pulling out your calendar)*	**네, 좋아요! 연락할게요.** ne, jo-a-yo! yeol-lak-hal-ge-yo Usually a warm goodbye, not a plan. A real plan comes with a day and place.
A colleague thanks you ~~천만에요~~	**아니에요.** a-ni-e-yo Correct but theatrical. Koreans brush off thanks by saying it was nothing.

People, meals and feelings

What AI gives you	What Koreans say
A coworker sneezes ~~축복해요~~	*(say nothing)* Korean has no sneeze response. If they keep sneezing, ask 괜찮아요?
Texting a female friend two years older (you're a woman) ~~저원아, 내일 시간 있어?~~	**언니, 내일 시간 있어요?** eon-ni, nae-il si-gan i-sseo-yo Older friends get a title: 언니/오빠 from women, 누나/형 from men.
Calling over a woman at a small restaurant ~~아줌마~~	**저기요, 주문할게요.** jeo-gi-yo, ju-mun-hal-ge-yo 아줌마 labels her age and many find it dismissive. 사장님 works for owners.
Telling a Korean about Korea ~~저희 나라~~	**우리나라** u-ri-na-ra You can't humble a country the listener also belongs to.
Before eating a meal someone else paid for ~~식사 감사합니다~~	**잘 먹겠습니다!** jal meok-get-seum-ni-da Fixed phrases: 잘 먹겠습니다 before, 잘 먹었습니다 after.
A close friend left you out ~~실망했어~~	**좀 서운하다.** jom seo-un-ha-da 실망했어 judges them. 서운하다 is the gentle word for feeling overlooked.

Not sure about a sentence?

Every phrase here has a full page on our site, with more alternatives and the cultural reason behind it.

We're building a checker that reads what an AI wrote and tells you how it will sound to your boss, your partner's parents, or a friend. Subscribers get to try it first.

yanakorean.com

Seen a strange AI translation? Send it to us at hello@yanakorean.com and it may become the next entry.

Context Korean is an open-source project curated by native speakers. Operated by Fine Pearls (파인펄스).